Criticism

The balance of power theory was an attempt on the part of some of the international relations scholars to devise a law for international politics like other sciences. But the greatest difficulty one faces in the field of international relations is in the application of the theories derived from other disciplines. Therefore, it becomes difficult to accept the idea of balance of power just because it is old and a respectable theory.

Most scholars have come up with their suggestions that the principles of the theory are correct but the altered conditions prevent the balance of power system from operating correctly. As Morgenthau pointed out "…the balance of power in international affairs is only a particular manifestation of a general social principle to which all societies composed of a number of autonomous units owe their autonomy; that the balance of power and policies aiming at its preservation are not inevitable but are an essential stabilizing factor in a society of sovereign nations; and that the instability of the international balance of power is due not to the faultiness of the principle but to the particular conditions under which the principle must operate in a society of sovereign states".[14]

Organski points out several drawbacks of the concept. To him, the concept is based on erroneous assumptions that nations are fundamentally static units whose power is not changed from within and also the assumption that nations have no permanent ties with each other but move freely, motivated primarily by consideration of power. He says that nations are not static units that increase their power only through military aggressions, territorial aggrandizements and alliances. Given the modern changes in the pattern of international relations, nations can change by mobilizing national sentiments, improving the efficiency of social organizations, and by industrialization. Such increase and shifts in power cannot be counteracted through traditional mechanisms of the balance of power because a variety of economic, technological and socio-cultural changes may lead to the breakdown of one actor and the emergence of another. A theory which assumes that the major road to national power lies in waging wars and forming alliances has